

Program Manager Guide

WRAC Research Funding Portal

Washington State Wine Commission — Research Advisory Committee

Website: <https://wrac-portal.vercel.app/>

This guide covers the full system, including how researchers and committee members use it.

Practice environment: the site currently holds sample data and test accounts for you to learn with. None of it is real, and it will all be cleared before the first live cycle.

What this portal is for

This portal runs the Research Advisory Committee's annual funding process from start to finish—from the moment a researcher registers, through the committee's review and scoring, to the funding decisions and the report that goes to the Commission. Everything that used to move by email and spreadsheet lives in one place, and each person sees only what belongs to their role.

The four kinds of people involved

- **Researchers** — the scientists who apply for funding. They register, submit proposals, and later file progress and final reports. Their account carries over year to year.
- **Committee members** — the reviewers. You invite them; they don't sign themselves up. They read proposals, score them against your questions, and leave comments. Each reviewer works privately—they never see one another's scores.
- **You, the Program Manager** — you run everything: set up each year, approve researchers, invite reviewers, move the process along, run the funding meeting, and produce the report.
- **The Commission** — does not log in. At the end you generate a report of the committee's funding recommendations to hand to them.

The shape of a year

It helps to picture the whole cycle before the details. A typical year runs like this:

1. **You set up the year**—the calendar, the budget, the review questions, and which documents applicants must upload.
2. **Pre-proposals open** (typically mid-November). Researchers submit short outlines.
3. **The committee reviews the pre-proposals** and scores them.
4. **You decide which advance** and invite those researchers to submit full proposals.
5. **Full proposals open** (typically January). Invited researchers submit complete applications with budgets. Ongoing multi-year projects submit continuation requests here too.
6. **The committee reviews the full proposals** and scores them.
7. **The funding meeting**—the committee deliberates and you record funding decisions on a live screen that tracks the money.

8. You generate the Commission report and close the year.

9. Through the year, funded projects file the progress and final reports you schedule.

The portal keeps you on this path: a cycle moves through named stages, and each stage opens the right activity for the right people at the right time.

Signing in

Go to <https://wrac-portal.vercel.app/> in any web browser (Chrome, Safari, Edge, or Firefox all work). Enter your email and password. The portal decides what you see based on who you are—as the manager, you land on your dashboard.

Tip

Bookmark the website address so you don't have to type it each time. The portal works on a phone or tablet as well as a computer, though the funding meeting screen is best on a large display.

Your dashboard—the home screen

Your home screen is built around **what needs your attention right now**, shown first, with the broader status below. You'll typically see:

- **Pending registrations** — researchers waiting for you to approve their accounts.
- **New submissions since you last logged in** — a quick count of what's come in, so nothing surprises you.
- **Outstanding committee reviews** — how much reviewing the committee still owes.
- **Cycle tiles** — each active year, its current stage, the next deadline and how many days remain, and how many proposals have arrived and been funded.
- **Committee progress** — how many reviews are in, and which members are behind.

Click any tile to go straight to the detail behind it.

Setting up a research year (a “cycle”)

A **cycle** is one research year. You build a fresh one each year. Until you open it, researchers can't see it, so you can take your time getting it right.

Step 1 — Create the cycle

1. From your dashboard, go to the Cycles area and choose to create a new cycle.
2. Give it a name (for example, “2026 Research Cycle”) and the year.
3. Optionally enter the total budget now—you can also add it later, before the funding meeting.

Step 2 — Set the calendar

Open the cycle and fill in the key dates: when pre-proposals open and close, when pre-proposal reviews are due, when full proposals are due, and when full reviews are due. You can also set default due dates for progress and final reports here. The portal checks these dates make sense in order (a close date can't come before an open date) and tells you plainly if something's off. You can fill them in gradually.

Step 3 — Write the review questions

These are the questions each committee member answers when scoring. You set two sets—one for pre-proposals, one for full proposals. For each question you write the prompt and choose the score range (say, 0 to 10, or 1 to 5—each question can differ). Reviewers give a number and a comment for each one.

A real time-saver

Once you've run a year, you don't start from scratch. When setting up the next cycle you can **copy the questions from a previous year** and just tweak them. The same goes for the document list below.

Step 4 — Choose which documents applicants must upload

Researchers don't type their proposals into the portal—they upload documents you specify. You define the “slots” for each stage: for a full proposal you might require a narrative, a budget spreadsheet, and a CV. For each slot you set a name, whether it's required or optional, and which file types are allowed. You do this separately for pre-proposals, full proposals, progress reports, and final reports.

Approving researchers

Researchers sign themselves up, but they can't do anything until you approve them. This keeps out unwanted accounts and lets you confirm each applicant is legitimate.

1. When someone registers, they appear under **Pending registrations** on your dashboard.
2. Open the pending list to see their name, institution, email, and the CV they uploaded (click to view it).
3. Choose **Approve** or **Reject**. Approved researchers can immediately start applying; rejected ones are told they weren't approved.

Approval carries forward—a researcher you approve this year doesn't need approving again next year.

Inviting committee members

Committee members don't register themselves—you create their accounts, so you control exactly who reviews.

1. Go to the Committee area and choose to invite a member.
2. Enter their name and email. The portal creates their account and shows you a **temporary password on screen, once**.
3. Send that person their email address and the temporary password (by your own email, a call, or in person—the portal doesn't email it for them yet).
4. The first time they sign in, they're required to set their own new password before they can do anything.

Important

The temporary password is shown only once. Copy it before you leave that screen. If it's lost, you can invite again or reset it.

Moving the cycle through its stages

A cycle advances through stages, and each stage is what actually opens and closes activity. For example, researchers can only submit pre-proposals while the cycle is in the “pre-proposal open” stage. You move it forward (and back, if you clicked too soon) from the cycle’s page.

The portal won’t let you skip ahead without the pieces in place—for instance, it won’t open pre-proposals until you’ve set the pre-proposal dates. If something’s missing, it tells you exactly what.

The stages, in order:

- **Setup** — you’re still building it; researchers can’t see it.
- **Pre-proposals open** — researchers submit outlines.
- **Pre-proposal review** — the committee scores them.
- **Advance decision** — you choose which move forward.
- **Full proposals open** — invited researchers (and continuations) submit full applications.
- **Full proposal review** — the committee scores them.
- **Deliberation** — the funding meeting.
- **Funding decisions** — amounts are recorded.
- **Closed** — the year is finalized.

Reviewing scores and advancing pre-proposals

Once the committee has scored the pre-proposals, open the cycle's proposals dashboard. For each proposal you'll see its total and average score across all reviewers, how many reviews are in, and you can open any proposal to read every reviewer's scores and comments (you're the only one who sees all of them together).

For each pre-proposal you record the committee's decision—**advance** it to a full proposal, or **decline** it. Advancing is the decision; it doesn't yet create the full proposal.

Inviting full proposals

When you're ready—typically once you've made all the advance decisions and moved the cycle to the full-proposal stage—you invite the advanced researchers to submit. Inviting creates an empty full-proposal draft in that researcher's account, which they then fill in. They can't start a full proposal on their own; your invitation is what opens the door.

Continuations—ongoing multi-year projects

Multi-year projects don't get funded once for three years; they re-apply each year for that year's money. When you set up a new cycle, the portal shows you which previously funded projects still have years remaining. You invite each one to submit a **continuation request**—like a full proposal, but it skips the pre-proposal step. The researcher sees what they originally projected for this year next to what they're now asking, and the committee sees the project's full history when they review it.

Running the funding meeting

This is the centerpiece. During the committee's deliberation, you drive a single live screen (best shown on a projector or shared display) called the **allocation tool**.

It lists every proposal on the table, sorted by score, showing what each requested. As the committee decides, you enter a funding amount for each—**which can be less than requested**—or decline it. At the top, a running tally always shows the total budget, how much you've allocated so far, and how much remains.

- The remaining figure updates instantly with each decision.
- If the committee tentatively over-commits, the remaining figure goes negative and turns red—the tool warns you but never blocks you, because deliberation is fluid.
- A comments button on each proposal opens all the reviewers' comments, handy for reading aloud.
- You can change or clear any decision as the discussion evolves.

Off-cycle proposals, if you ever use them, are funded from a separate source and are kept out of this annual tally on purpose.

The Commission report

When funding is decided, open the cycle's report page. It shows the funded projects with their awarded amounts and their multi-year plan totals, plus the budget summary. Use your browser's **Print** → **Save as PDF** to produce the document for the Commission. (The page hides all the app buttons when printing, so you get a clean report.)

Progress and final reports

Funded projects owe reports during and after the work. You decide how many and when.

1. From the cycle's reports area, create a report for a funded project—choose whether it's a progress (status) report or a final report, add a label, and set a due date (it pre-fills from your cycle defaults).
2. The researcher sees it on their dashboard, writes a narrative, uploads the required documents, and submits it.
3. You (and the committee, for context) can read submitted reports. If a researcher needs to fix something after submitting, you can reopen it.

*When a researcher submits a **final** report, the project is automatically marked completed. If a researcher ends a project early, the portal flags that a final report is owed.*

Accepting a late submission

If a deadline passes but you want to accept a proposal anyway, open that proposal and turn on the **late submission** allowance for it. That single proposal can then be submitted despite the deadline; everyone else stays held to it.

Practice first—try all three roles

The best way to understand the portal is to walk through it as each kind of user. The practice site has ready-made accounts for exactly this. Sign in as each, click around, and you'll see what your researchers and reviewers experience.

Before you start

These are **test accounts with made-up people and sample proposals**. Nothing here is real, and all of it—including these logins—will be cleared before the first real cycle. Practice freely; you can't break anything that matters.

To switch roles, use Log out (top of the screen), then sign in with the next account.

There are several researchers and committee members so you can run a realistic cycle—multiple proposals competing for funding, and several reviewers scoring each. The three newer researchers already have a placeholder CV on file, so they can submit right away.

Role	Sign in with	Password
Program Manager	mgr-test@twomountainwinery.com	Manager-Test-2026!
Committee member	committee-test@twomountainwinery.com	Committee-Test-2026!
Committee member	committee2-test@twomountainwinery.com	Committee2-Test-2026!
Committee member	committee3-test@twomountainwinery.com	Committee3-Test-2026!
Researcher	researcher-test@twomountainwinery.com	Researcher-Test-2026!
Researcher	researcher2-test@twomountainwinery.com	Researcher2-Test-2026!
Researcher	researcher3-test@twomountainwinery.com	Researcher3-Test-2026!
Researcher	researcher4-test@twomountainwinery.com	Researcher4-Test-2026!
Rejected researcher	reject-test@twomountainwinery.com	Reject-Test-2026!

A suggested practice run

1. Sign in as the **manager** and look over the sample cycles—open one and see its calendar, questions, and document list. Better still, create a fresh test cycle of your own from scratch.
2. Log out and sign in as one of the **researchers** to see their dashboard and submit a proposal. Do this for two or three of them, so you have several proposals competing in one cycle.
3. Log out and sign in as each **committee member** in turn and score the proposals—giving different scores from each reviewer, so you can see how the totals and averages combine.
4. Back as the **manager**, open the cycle's proposals dashboard to see the combined scores and every reviewer's comments, then run the allocation tool to fund them and generate the Commission report.

Running a full cycle this way—several proposals, several reviewers—is the best test of the whole system, and the closest thing to a real year.

The two forwardable guides (for researchers and committee members) explain each of those roles in full—you can share them as-is when the real cycle begins.

A couple of things still coming

A few refinements are planned before the first real cycle, so you know if you notice them:

- Researchers can't yet update their profile or replace their CV after approval—that page is coming. For now a CV is set at registration.
- The portal doesn't yet send automatic email reminders (deadlines, review requests, approvals). That's planned; for now those nudges are manual.
- Existing multi-year projects already underway will be loaded in before the February full-proposal round so their continuations work.

As you practice, note anything confusing or missing—your feedback shapes the refinements before go-live.